

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

This blog appeared on the author's personal webpage:

Translation Apps

On a recent trip to Japan I was amazed to see hotel staff in the hotel I was staying at using what turned out to be a translation gadget. The reception staff wore them around their neck to translate questions and answers from Japanese into Chinese and English so that they could communicate with tourists successfully even though they only spoke Japanese. The fast and accurate translation greatly improved our trip as there were no miscommunications and all the staff could quickly answer any problems we had. Although at times the translation was a little bit strange, it was never too bad to understand.

Translation apps and machines such as Google Translate are developing so fast that they are now able to do many tasks in both written and spoken translation. While I understand that they are still not able to do complicated translations of literature and legal documents, they are already effective in many areas of business and tourism. Westerners in China often use translation apps to help understand menus.

I am sure that translation devices will continue to develop and soon will be able to translate from Chinese to English more effectively than most university graduates. This raises the question of whether or not we need to invest so much time and money in learning foreign languages at all.

Why should Hongkongers spend 15 or 16 years learning English or Putonghua if they can buy a cheap app that can help them communicate even more accurately?

Your ICT class is discussing how technology is changing the world. Your group has been asked to discuss translation devices. You may want to talk about:

- the advantages and disadvantages of using translation devices
- whether translation devices should be allowed at school
- whether learning languages is still important
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. What language would you like to learn?
2. Have you ever used a translation app?
3. Is it fun speaking a foreign language?
4. Are translation apps easy to use?
5. Who do you think will benefit from translation apps?
6. Will fewer people learn foreign languages in future?
7. Why are some people better at learning languages than others?
8. Do you worry about technology becoming too essential?